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Damsels and darlings: decoding gender equality in video game communities

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ABSTRACT

Gender stereotypes are a known issue in video games, where female characters are often hyper-sexualized and relegated to dis-empowering roles. Numerous quantitative studies paint a grim picture of video game communities as hyper-masculine spaces complicit in reproducing harmful gender ideologies. Missing from the literature are qualitative inquiries of the meaning gamers assign to their engagement with a medium that is known for underrepresenting and objectifying women. This study uses qualitative textual content analysis of an influential, popular Internet video game forum—the largest of its kind—where gamers respond to questions posed by members about gender in video games. My findings show that gamers centralize the role of sexual agency and sexual empowerment to construct multiple, nuanced discourses for understanding gender stereotypes in games. These discourses mirror broader feminist debates about the achievability of sexual empowerment within hyper-sexualized cultural contexts. As video games grow in popularity, their ability to generate meaning among increasingly diverse audiences requires continued investigation. By engaging with gamers as they make sense of gender representation in games, researchers can glean insight into the many ways gamers envision change within the video game industry.

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Introduction

Gender stereotypes are a recurring theme in sociological inquiries of video game consumption. Extant research explores the prevalence of gendered stereotypes in female characters (B. Beasley and T. C. Standley 2002), sexism in the gaming industry (X. Kondrat 2015), and the gaming community as a site of toxic masculinity (B. Paaßen, T. Morgenroth and M. Stratemeyer 2017). It is well established that female video game characters are under-represented as protagonists in AAA games,¹ and are frequently subjected to objectification and violence through game design (Beasley and Standley 2002; H. D. Fisher 2015; J. Fox and W. Y. Tang 2014). Recently, the number of prominent female characters in newly released AAA games has increased (e.g., *Horizon: Zero Dawn*, *The Last of Us*) accompanied by an upward trend in female and middle-aged gamers (Entertainment Software Association [ESA] 2017; ESA 2018). Given these changing trends,

video games illustrate an example of how entertainment media engage themes that can encourage multiple “readings” by various audiences, including oppositional readings towards highly politicized topics (e.g., gender diversity and equality) (J. C. Alexander 2006; S. Hall [1973] 1980). Moreover, digital spaces (blogs, fandoms, Internet forums, etc.) are increasingly used by consumers to examine these sociopolitical issues in ways that reify or disrupt existing cultural paradigms. This study explores how online gaming communities respond to newly released female protagonists by engaging discussions of gender stereotypes and diversity. Specifically, this study centralizes concepts such as sexual agency and sexual empowerment in these discussions.

Video games and gender

Video games occupy a prominent cultural position in today’s social world, with an estimated 75% of American teenagers (ages 12–17) and 49% of adults playing games on a weekly basis (A. Lenhart et al. 2008a; A. Lenhart, S. Jones and A. MacGill 2008b). In the United States, 64% of households boast at least one gamer, with 60% of Americans playing video games daily (ESA 2018), and estimates indicate roughly 23 million Canadians (or 62% of the Canadian population) are gamers (ESA Canada 2018). In 2014, global revenue from video game sales reached 64 USD billion, more than both the film and music industries combined (B. McKernan 2015). This revenue is generated from the sale of computer games, console games (Xbox, Playstation), and—increasingly—mobile games (ESA 2018). Today, the ubiquity of video games in popular culture is evidenced in several ways, from easily recognizable characters such as Pac-Man and Nintendo’s Mario, and the inclusion of gaming “cult classics” in the Museum of Modern Art in New York City, to the publication of video game commentary in mainstream media outlets, and the opening of a World Video Game Hall of Fame in 2015 (McKernan 2015).

With the rise of the video game industry has come a change in the demographics of gamers. Despite the traditional image of the young male gamer (R. Kowert, R. Festl and T. Quandt 2014), large-scale polls have consistently shown nearly equal numbers of female and male gamers (Paaßen, Morgenroth and Stratemeyer 2017). In addition to an increasing number of female gamers, the same polls show that the average age of gamers is rising (Kondrat 2015). According to the Entertainment Software Association (2018), the average gamer is 34 years old, with women aged 18 years and older representing a greater portion of the gamer population than adolescent males. These changes are driven in part by the rise of mobile games and the increasing popularity of “casual” games. Despite these changing demographics and the permeance of video games in popular culture, the content and targeted audience of many major game studios has remained largely static, favouring young white men (Paaßen, Morgenroth and Stratemeyer 2017). Consequentially, efforts to diversify AAA game content by including more female characters have fallen short of achieving gender equity.

Current research on gender and video games paints a grim picture of both the industry and its player-base, and with good reason. Since the 1980s, research shows a consistent pattern of female characters as the disproportionate targets of in-game violence (Dietz 1998), while they are under-represented in games (C. Braun and J. Giroux 1989), on marketing material (Fisher 2015; J. Jansz and R. G. Martis 2007; E. F. Provenzo 1991), and in leading roles (B. Gailey 1993). In a content analysis of

popular Nintendo and Sega Genesis video games, Dietz (1998) found that 41% of games excluded female characters entirely, and that female characters were disproportionately portrayed as submissive, cute, and unthreatening (e.g., the damsel in distress). Attempting to update Dietz's findings in light of newly released games, Beasley and Standley (2002) similarly performed a content analysis of a random selection of video game characters, looking at gender, body type, and clothing choices. Their findings indicate that an overwhelming majority (86%) of game characters are male, and that female characters adorn significantly less clothing than males. Beasley and Standley (2002) conclude that female characters are overwhelmingly portrayed in unimportant roles that frequently involve their over-sexualization. Though more recent research (Jansz and Martis 2007) indicates a rise in female protagonists within AAA games, such studies are limited given sampling strategies that purposefully include games with diverse character casts.

Embedded in video game research are concerns over the socializing effects of games towards harmful gender roles and stereotypes. A long-standing body of research highlights the role of media consumption in the construction of meaning in everyday life, including the meaning audiences attribute to social relations and personal identities (J. D. Brown, C. R. Dykers, J. R. Steele and A. B. White 1994; J. Cohen 2001; K. E. Dill and K. P. Thill 2007; D. C. Giles and J. Maltby 2004; Jansz and Martis 2007). For example, V. S. Beck, S. Boys, C. Rose and E. Beck (2012) explore how the consumption of games that sexually objectify women and/or allow players to engage in violence against female characters encourages rape myth-supportive attitudes in male players. Regarding female players, J. Fox, G. N. Vailenson and L. Tricase (2013) found that women who embodied overly sexualized game avatars were more likely to adopt misogynistic attitudes, including self-objectification and rape myth acceptance. Dietz (1998) takes a symbolic interactionist approach to argue that video games have become agents of socialization and identity development in children, emphasizing narratives of women as subordinate to men, and of violence against women as a problem-solving mechanism for completing tasks. Socialization through harmful gender roles and ideologies is of particular concern in video games given the highly interactive nature of games where players are encouraged to embody and control their characters.

Misogynist gender stereotypes and ideologies extend beyond game content and into tangential spaces for game-related consumption (such as online gaming forums, blogs and fandoms, gaming magazines, premier expos and conventions, and the game industry itself) (K. L. Gray, G. Voorhees and E. Vossen 2018). Within gaming magazines, Fisher (2015) notes that visual depictions of female avatars are far less likely to be accompanied by text than male avatars, and those with captions contained provocative, sexist remarks. Magazine articles referencing games with character creators or choose-your-gender options overwhelmingly depicted male avatar options in both pictures and descriptive text. Women are often considered outsiders in gaming communities (including gaming conventions, and gaming industry workspaces) and are perceived by some men as violating normative gendered behaviours by engaging with these traditionally masculine spaces (J. deWinter and C. A. Kocurek 2017; Fox and Tang 2014; N. B. Huntemann 2017). In response, males in these spaces may resort to harassment—both on and offline—to “socially punish” female players (Fox and Tang 2014). These tangential gaming spaces are thus constructed as male-only spaces where men can establish their position as “real

gamers”, in part by excluding women (Fisher 2015; Fox and Tang 2014; Paaßen, Morgenroth and Stratemeyer 2017).

Feminism in game studies

Given the prevalence of masculine ideals in gaming spaces and the persistence of prestigious gaming studios in marketing to a presumably male audience, it is perhaps unsurprising that shifting gender demographics in games have gone largely unacknowledged by the general public and (until recently) unattended to in game research. Within academia, feminist game studies scholars have recently begun to problematize the quantitative focus on white, adolescent male gamers by expanding their focus to a more eclectic set of gamers, including gamers of colour, of diverse ages, and of queer and gender nonconforming identities (J. Bryce and J. Rutter 2002; J. Malkowski and T. A. M. Russworm 2017; B. Ruberg 2018; A. Shaw 2014; A. Shaw, E. W. Lauteria, H. Yang, C. J. Persaud and A. M. Cole 2019). Further, feminist scholars have pushed to expand the field of game studies past its initial preoccupation with code/software studies, and player/machine actions towards a nuanced attendance to representation and identity in games as “high-stakes matters” (Malkowski and Russworm 2017, 3). What is pivotal in these works is the recognition of contested (and often reductive) understandings of concepts such as identity, and representation. Shaw (2014, 196) unpacks the importance (or lack thereof) of media representation to gamers, arguing “both texts and audiences are impossible to pin down in terms of singular meanings and specific identities.” Rather than studying the importance of representation solely from the point of view of individual players—be it of gender, sexuality, race, or other common identifiers—Shaw (2014) argues that game studies must acknowledge how gamers themselves understand identity and the social and political contexts in which games are consumed. Such a standpoint aligns with M. Consalvo (2012) call for feminist scholars to document, archive and build databases of how both gamer networks and game developers understand and respond to calls for increased representation and diversity in games. By building a collective history of womens’ and girls’ involvement in games, feminist scholars directly challenge the predominant “story of women as passive, casual, or non-essential participants within a culture dominated by endless narratives of men and hegemonic masculinity” (Gray, Voorhees and Vossen 2018, 5) While current game studies have shifted focus to diverse gaming audiences, and the increased importance of identity and representation, there is a lacuna in research on the role of concepts such as sexual empowerment and sexual agency in discussions of gender representation in video games. Further, missing is a discussion of how gamers make sense of these concepts specifically in the context of an industry that is permeated with hypersexualized depictions of women.

The sexualization of culture and the role of sexual agency

The hypersexualized role of women in video games and gaming communities occurs in a larger context that some scholars call the “sexualization of culture” (also referred to as the “pornification” of culture) (R. Gill 2008; A. Levy 2005; S. Paasonen, K. Nikunen and L. Saarenmaa 2007; N. Walter 2010). The sexualization of culture is used to indicate “a contemporary preoccupation with sexual values, practices, and identities; the public shift

to more permissive sexual attitudes; the proliferation of sexual texts; [and] the apparent breakdown of rules, categories and regulations designed to keep the obscene at bay" (F. V. Attwood 2006, 78). Indeed, the popularity of exaggerated bosoms and bikini-clad warriors exemplifies the reach of "pornification" into industries perceived as catering to adolescents (R. L. Collins 2011).

Current debates on the severity of and reactions to the sexualization of culture give prominence to concepts such as sexual empowerment and agency (Gill 2012; S. Lamb and Z. D. Peterson 2012; S. K. Murnen and L. Smolak 2012), although the centrality of sexual agency/empowerment in these discussions is highly contested (Lamb and Peterson 2012). On one side are scholars who regard empowerment narratives as empty rhetoric, packaged and sold to women in a "shiny, feisty, postfeminist packaging that obscures the continued underlying sexism" (Gill 2012, 737). They argue that the sexual objectification of women in media has led to a number of "disempowering consequences", such as self-objectification, internalized misogyny, and self-surveillance of their feminine behaviours and appearance (Murnen and Smolak 2012, 728). Such studies are consistent with the limited research available on female gamers, who are shown to internalize misogynistic attitudes when embodying a sexualized game avatar (J. Fox, G. N. Vailenson and L. Tricase 2013). On the other side of this debate, scholars attempt to mobilize women's agency and empowerment to celebrate certain sexual depictions (such as burlesque or recreational pole dancing) as liberating, championing women's unprecedented control over their own sexuality. From this perspective, sexual empowerment involves the successful negotiation of wanted and unwanted sexual acts, and is the culmination of sexual desire and pleasure (Lamb and Peterson 2012). Embedded within these debates is the underlying issue of whether sexual agency can be achieved in a hyper-sexualized culture, or if that culture must first be dismantled before women can experience genuine empowerment. Such scholarly debates beg the question of how gaming communities make sense of hyper-sexualized game content as they respond to gender stereotypes.

Knowledge production through gaming: constructing meaning

Online gaming communities who engage in discussions of game content and culture provide an example of "interactive audiences" (S. E. Bird 2003; H. Jenkins 2006). Using the works of Pierre Levy on *collective intelligence*, Jenkins (2006) argues that scholars must revisit dominant paradigms in audience studies that conceptualize fandoms in terms of resistance to cultural norms. Instead, Jenkins urges us to think of interactive audiences as "knowledge communities" where members engage in collective discussions in which they negotiate and develop knowledge about the text. As D. E. Alvermann and M. C. Hagood (2000) note, when fans engage a text, they do so multiple times. This re-reading allows fans to negotiate character relations, narratives, and broader sociopolitical themes (Bird 2003; Hall [1973] 1980). It is through the reciprocal, collective, and reflexive nature of communication that online knowledge communities reify or destabilize power narratives and encourage cultural change (Jenkins 2006).

Fans as interactive audiences form a crucial component of Stuart Hall's canonical work on "Encoding/decoding" texts. (Hall [1973] 1980). Hall ([1973] 1980) argues that the meanings embedded (i.e., "encoded") in media by its producers are not rigid and permanent, but rather that audiences negotiate meanings through the process of

interpretation (i.e., “decoding”). This process of meaning-making through decoding involves an understanding of the “denotation, connotation, [and] ideology” embedded within texts (L. Woodstock 2016, 400). Hall offers three ways in which audiences can decode a text through different types of readings: dominant, negotiated, and oppositional. Dominant readings reflect the ideological messages encoded by media producers that privilege hegemonic, normative messages that “appear to naturally structure reality” (Woodstock 2016, 400). Such dominant readings are generally “preferred” as they align with messages encoded in media during production (Malkowski and Russworm 2017; A. Shaw 2017). Second, negotiated readings acknowledge the dominant reading of a text while accommodating exceptions to the dominant reading’s normative framework. Finally, oppositional readings recognize the hegemony of the dominant reading while offering a counter-narrative, or interpretation that directly challenges the ideological assumptions within the dominant encoded message (Hall [1973] 1980; Woodstock 2016).

This model of encoding/decoding acknowledges the potential for entertainment media (e.g., film, music, video games) to stimulate discussions among consumers about broad sociopolitical matters such as sexism, racism, and inequality (Alexander 2006; R. N. Jacobs 2007, 2012; J. Wu 2011). Further, this model recognizes the shifting meanings and importance gamers give to issues of identity and representation (Shaw 2014). The encoding of sociopolitical messages in entertainment media often results in the public discussion and decoding of these issues in online spaces, such as blogs, fandoms, and online forums (Jacobs 2007, 2012). One notable example of this type of work in the context of video games is McKernan’s (2015) analysis of video game commentary in response to a highly publicized debate over the racial imagery in *Resident Evil 5*’s promotional material. McKernan (2015) found that online gaming forum users constructed competing narratives over *Resident Evil 5*’s racial imagery, adhering to a dominant reading of “colour-blind racism” in order to justify the problematic imagery found in Capcom’s promotional material.

While video game content is a compelling illustration of the sexualization of culture, the role of sexual agency and empowerment—which are centralized in feminist debates—have not been directly explored by scholars in this context. Thus, my research examines how members of a popular Internet video game forum, NeoGAF, respond to gender stereotypes in games with particular focus on the role of sexual agency and empowerment in my analysis.

Methods

This research uses content analysis to investigate the attitudes and responses of an online community of dedicated video gamers (colloquially known as “gaffers”) to gender stereotypes and objectification in AAA video games. NeoGAF is currently the largest Internet video game forum, with dozens of recent or currently active discussions on gender stereotypes and female characters available to the public. On their website, NeoGAF defines themselves as a community of “hardcore gamers, enthusiast press, and video game industry developers and publishers”. Though most members do not partake in discussion forums, NeoGAF’s influence on the reception, coverage and development of video games is well-established (McKernan 2015). As of October 2017, NeoGAF boasts

over 190,000 registered members, and 830,000 unique discussion threads, with the most popular threads eliciting thousands of responses from users.

The data in this study consist of four purposively sampled NeoGAF discussion threads on the topics of gender diversity and sexual agency in video games. Using site-specific Google search commands (i.e., ["sexual agency" site: www.neogaf.com]), I utilized six keywords related to my research question to find discussion threads: AAA games, female protagonist(s), gender diversity, gender stereotypes, sexual agency, and sexual empowerment (for keywords methodology see A. Ghaziani and M. J. Ventresca 2005; R. Williams 1976). I used three criteria to narrow my search results: all threads were selected from the first page of results (based on Google's keyword database and PageRank algorithm); threads were from the NeoGAF "Gaming" forum, as opposed to the "Off-Topic" forum to eliminate discussions unrelated to the gaming industry or game content; and threads must have at least one full page of responses (50 posts) to ensure nuanced discussion among multiple users.

Initially, I used only the first four keywords to find my sample (AAA games, female protagonist(s), gender diversity, gender stereotypes) based on recurring themes in the literature. After an initial open-coding of qualified threads, the recurrence of themes pertaining to sexual agency and empowerment led me to inductively extend my search to include these terms. In total, four discussion threads met my sampling criteria, with all four threads collectively spanning a three-year period between December 2014 and July 2017. Though most of NeoGAF's traffic comes from the United States, individuals from all over the world can register to participate in discussions.

The NeoGAF threads included in this study ranged from 358 posts (Thread #3) to 603 posts (Thread #4) in length and encompassed text responses, visuals (such as game screenshots, or concept art), as well as external links to videos and articles on topics of gender diversity in games. Once discussion threads were converted into Word documents, I used NVivo to analyse the texts line by line. Qualitative content analysis allowed me to identify the "patterned ways in which interpretive communities render a topic meaningful by contextualizing the topic and placing it in an evaluative framework" (McKernan 2015, 233; see also D. L. Altheide 1987, 2000). To accomplish this, I employed a reproductive coding strategy alternating between theoretically grounded (deductive) codes, and inductive codes based upon recurring themes during a close reading of the texts (C. Ragin 1994). The use of analytic memos allowed me to track patterns in my data and follow-up on hunches of theoretical importance.

The combination of keywords and frame analysis is well suiting for understanding how social structure, action, and culture interact to create social change (Ghaziani and Ventresca 2005). Female protagonists are increasingly common in AAA games, mirroring shifting gendered demographics among gamers (with an estimated 40/60 ratio of female/male gamers). Such changes are perhaps reflective of a cultural shift in understandings of gender diversity and sexual agency among gamers. To detect frames constructed by gaffers, I ask two questions of each thread: (1) What core concept(s) unify the central ideas of gaffers? (2) How do the concept(s) encourage meaning-making and/or the application of keywords in my study (e.g., "sexual agency", "gender stereotypes", etc.) (adopted from Ghaziani and Ventresca 2005, 534). For example, I used the code "*sexual without sexualizing*" to demarcate the importance gaffers assign to building female characters that exert

agency over their sexuality without falling prey to well-known tropes and stereotypes that objectify women.

Qualitative coding schemes lend themselves to concerns of reliability and reproducibility (Cambell et al. 2013). To ascertain the reliability of my coding scheme, a second coder was employed. Given Cambell et al.'s (2013, 15) assertion that "simpler coding schemes are better than complex ones" I simplified my codebook to include only the broader, "global" themes I encountered in my data. These global themes correspond with the overarching narratives constructed by gaffers when discussing issues of gender equality in games. The three major themes I trained my second coder on were: *misogyny is alive and well*, *desexualize games*, and *sexual without sexualizing*. After my coder was trained on these three codes, I randomly selected a portion (10%) of my data for reliability testing, which was repeated until we reached a proportional agreement of .80 or higher (Campbell et al. 2013).

NeoGAF forums come with several limitations. First, I do not have access to the demographic information of users (such information volunteered within forum discussions is uncommon). Secondly, NeoGAF is a heavily moderated website where membership is neither automatic, nor guaranteed. To request membership, individuals must register using an Internet Service Provider, workplace, or educational email address. The use of institutional emails potentially skews the demographic composition of users towards educated and working-class individuals. Users are then waitlisted pending approval by NeoGAF staff. Only approved members have access to forum archives, and can create, or respond to, active discussions. This presents a significant barrier when accessing older discussion posts, limiting the ability to examine how gaffers' attitudes change over time. NeoGAF moderators also remove posts that are openly derogatory, inflammatory, or incite hate-speech, and bans members who engage in such discourses. Therefore, the narratives constructed by NeoGAF users may differ greatly from other online forums with less moderation. Despite these limitations, NeoGAF forums present a unique opportunity to address an overlooked empirical case in sociological understandings of gender stereotypes in video games by giving voice to a community of active and highly influential gamers. NeoGAF's closed membership policy diminishes anonymity and ensures a higher level of personal responsibility among users. As such, NeoGAF forums are highly organized, stay on-topic, and lack much of the "trolling"² and spam that exists on open membership forums. NeoGAF's industry influence positions it as a compelling site for examining the broader social significance of video games and sociopolitical issues they elicit. I now turn to the results, which are organized based on the dominant readings employed by gaffers when conceptualizing gender diversity and sexual agency among female protagonists.

NeoGAF's debate over the role of sexual agency in video games

Conversations on NeoGAF of sexualization and gender stereotypes in video games largely fall within three themes: *misogyny is alive and well*, *desexualize games*, and *sexual without sexualizing*. The narratives associated with each theme construct different readings of the impact of media on culture, the prevalence of gendered power dynamics, and the path forward for disrupting those power dynamics (and if they should be disrupted at all).

Together, these three readings unpack some of the root causes of sexism and gender inequality in the video game industry and communities.

Misogyny is alive and well

The theme *misogyny is alive and well* encompasses a narrative produced (or recognized) by gaffers that is largely consistent with existing literature on gender stereotypes in games (Beck et al. 2012; Dietz 1998; Fox and Tang 2014). In other words, *misogyny is alive and well* follows from a dominant reading/decoding of game content. For these gaffers, the sexualization of women in games is both normalized, and expected in an industry that is traditionally dominated by men: “mostly males play these games ... and so it makes sense to appeal to their strong sex drive; ‘sex sells’ as they say.” This justification highlights the importance some gaffers place on traditional ideals of masculinity, and the prioritization of these ideals over ensuring an inclusive environment.

Inherent in this narrative is the naturalization of the male gaze (a concept introduced by Mulvey 1975) in the video game industry. For these gaffers, including “good” female characters will come as a result of efforts to create better video game characters, overall. As one gaffer notes, “the problem with one dimensional female characters with no character traits other than boobs isn’t that it’s sexist ... but rather [it] makes for a bad character.” Thus, these gaffers cite lazy writing by developers who rely on overused tropes to sell female characters, effectively shifting the blame from gamers to the industry itself. The same gaffer goes on to note that “good female characters will naturally come about as a result of demanding better characters, which debates about boob size and sexualization completely dilute from and miss the point entirely.” Rather than problematizing the male gaze in the gaming community as contributing to the sexualization of female characters, this gaffer “passes the buck” onto developers to simply create better characters. Such readings do little to challenge the power narratives embedded in game production, and provide no concrete solutions for how to desexualize women in games.

Gaffers who do not consider sexual images of women in games to be problematic are often quick to note that the sexualization of female characters is, in fact, *enjoyable* to many players: “the only thing that the sexualization of a female actually means in a game is how much the creator felt like making a hot chick ... because his audience is mostly made up of other people who also like hot chicks.” This quote demonstrates how some gaffers downplay the role of sexism in video games by denying the ability of media to embed powerful, harmful messages about gender roles and stereotypes (Collins 2011; Murnen and Smolak 2012). Here, feminist criticism of games is met with dismissive remarks: “I like to think most women are not brainwashed idiots who need to be empowered by video games, or any other media.” Encouragement of sexualized women in media through dominant readings of a text can lead audiences to accept sexualized female roles as both normative and ideal (Smolack and Murnen 2012), an issue that is compounded upon when male pleasure is prioritized over nonsexual female representation. Along these lines, some gaffers project this sense of male pleasure onto female gamers. Comparing the video game industry to adult videos, this gaffer notes “the audience isn’t all male, but the female audience somehow seems to enjoy male empowerment and female humiliation.” This gaffer goes on to conclude that “women [are] a cruel lot, they basically hate each other and love seeing other women suffer.” Though this

gaffer notes issues of self-objectification, and internalized misogyny among women, they fail to construct these problems as *symptomatic* of large-scale sexism, and instead position women as contributing to sexism.

Though several gaffers displayed misogynistic attitudes in discussions of gender diversity in games, other gaffers discuss this theme in terms of the issues such attitudes pose. These gamers engage in a negotiated reading of game content by referencing problematic narratives (such as those explored above) as an obstacle to more inclusive games. These attitudes might be individual-level, or industry-level. For instance, gaffers who are critical of the *misogyny is alive and well* theme are quick to criticize individual-level claims akin to “it’s just a video game” that dismiss the experiences of female gamers who feel marginalized and express concerns on discussion threads. On a macro-level, they recognize the role of gendered power imbalances that elevate the male audience in games, and discourage game developers from creating heterosexual female leads: “it’s because straight men find it gross to play a straight woman hooking up with a guy. I’m not kidding, it’s so incredibly fucked up, self-centered, and possessive.” These gaffers note that even if female protagonists have romantic plotlines, they are most likely to be written as lesbian characters in such a way that reifies dominant readings by maintaining sexual appeal for a straight male audience. Until the video game industry ceases pandering to this audience, these respondents note that it will be difficult to diversify gender representations in games.

Desexualize games

The theme, *desexualize games* is embedded in a narrative among some gaffers that the video game industry as a whole contains too many sexually explicit themes. This oppositional reading is consistent with current academic and political debates about the “sexualization of culture” (sometimes called the “pornification” of culture), which denotes the proliferation of sexualized images and themes in mass media in recent decades (Gill 2012). This narrative conflates sexualization with objectification while acknowledging the male gaze, and out-of-context sex in video games. For example, when debating the clothing of a female character, Fran, (*Final Fantasy XII*, Square Enix, 2006) one gaffer notes that “every single aspect of her design is aimed at appealing to men, right down to the ridiculous stiletto heels she wears ... they’re just there to elongate her legs and make her look appealing to men.” This same user also goes on to note that Fran’s clothing is ill-suited for the context of the game; she is a member of a forested, tree-dwelling tribe where stiletto heels serve little functionality.

Indeed, the argument that sex is often out of place in games dominates this reading of game content. Gaffers note that sexual narratives in games are often shallow, confusing, and used to perpetuate harmful ideas of sex as a “reward” one earns and is thus entitled to:

I’m still totally confused as to why it became a normal thing to have sex in games when the game’s story doesn’t have anything to do with sex. Even the best love stories in other mediums generally don’t have their characters going for a random romp mid-plot. Gratuitous sex is the stuffs [*sic*] of mindless hollywood garbage, where we need to see an explosion or an ass every 10 minutes to keep us interested. I’m all for depiction of sex in games if it is meaningful to the plot in some way, but I’m really not a fan of having sex be the

“loot” at the end of a sidequest, regardless of the genders involved. It often comes off as tacky even if the intentions are good.

This perspective is consistent with existing literature on the over-representation of females as sexual objects in games (Kondrat 2015; Paaßen, Morgenroth and Stratemeyer 2017). Such a narrative is an example of an oppositional reading that recognizes and directly challenges underlying gendered power dynamics by problematizing the use of sexual themes to cater to the male gaze, socialize compulsory heterosexuality, and encourage harmful gender roles.

The *desexualize games* narrative is linked to discourses of empowerment in games. Current debates on the “sexualization of culture” center on the role of empowerment and choice among audience members (Attwood 2006; Levy 2005). For these gamers, “empowerment” is unattainable until broader issues of sexism and representation are addressed: “I’ve often heard that until female representation is fixed then it doesn’t matter what the authorial intent is, [sexualization] is still contributing to a larger issue.” Consistent with some scholars (Levy 2005), these gaffers are critical of empowerment narratives (i.e., empowerment through sexualization) as naturalizing and obscuring continued underlying sexism: “after all, this problem is a larger trend and these larger trends are what shapes a culture’s views.” Such a reading offers a “counter-hegemonic explanation” of gendered power dynamics in game content (Woodstock 2016, 401). This view challenges gamers who opt to dissect female characters and games on a case-by-case basis to discern whether each character or game is empowering or oppressive, such as the gaffers who discussed Fran’s clothing above. One gaffer notes that the prevalence and frequency of oversexualization in games leads to “explanations [that] sound more like excuses. Oh she looks like that because of x, y, z backstory- well, why is it that the backstory always makes women reveal more skin?” This macro-level approach to understanding oversexualization in games problematizes micro-level justifications as largely failing to combat underlying power dynamics and sexism, effectively decoding game content through an oppositional reading.

Sexual without sexualizing: enter sexual agency

Gaffers who encourage the *sexual without sexualizing* narrative note that to combat sexism, AAA game developers have largely begun to exclude sexual and romantic narratives altogether from games featuring female protagonists. These gamers are quick to acknowledge the strides made within the AAA game industry to diversify characters: “games are much more diverse now than they were years ago” and “Sony’s three current biggest franchises (Uncharted, The Last of Us, Horizon) all have women protagonists.” Though these gaffers praise new female leads as being dynamic, complex, well-rounded characters, they are also quick to note the lack of sexual themes overall, and specifically a lack of heterosexual romance options for female protagonists: “it’s a broad observation that female protagonists almost never seem to have straight male love interests.” Although not overly critical of newer, nonsexual female protagonists themselves, these gaffers *are* critical of developers’ choices to exclude heterosexual plot lines in games as pandering to a straight male playerbase. As one respondent notes, “I just see it as the publishers don’t want to make their target demographic uncomfortable by having

[their character] fuck or kiss a dude.” Thus, within this theme games with nonsexual female leads can be good, but should not be the standard for game developers anymore than should hypersexual female leads. Until a balance is achieved, users note that “video games [have not] reached good/diverse female representation, they’ve just created this one type of character”. Thus, perhaps ironically, these gaffers employ a negotiated reading to advocate for the inclusion of *more* sexual themes in AAA games featuring female protagonists.

These same gaffers also argue that the inclusion of sexual themes in new games must be articulated carefully to avoid objectification. The creation of sexual plots for female characters must, according to gaffers, coincide with a clear depiction of sexual agency: “it’d be nice to see a game with a female protagonist who actually enjoys sex, has it with who she wants to and on her own terms, and does not pander to the male gaze while doing so.” In meeting this vision of sexually empowered female characters, gaffers note that sexual agency can be written into various aspects of gameplay, including the narrative and character development, as well as clothing and animation options. In discussing Morrigan, a female character from the *Dragon Age* series one user notes that her sexualized appearance is justified because it “fits her character and she owns it.” This is demonstrated by Morrigan’s outfit design which aligns with her character’s theme, and her personality which “makes it evident that she approaches the question of sex casually, and can tend to use her sexuality as a tool at her disposal.” Ultimately these gaffers attempt to mobilize choice, agency, and empowerment to defend and even celebrate certain depictions of female characters involved in sexual plots. Such a negotiated reading embodies the argument that “sexualized culture” (such as pornography, burlesque, or pole dancing) can be liberating for women whose sexuality has been oppressively catered to male satisfaction (Holland and Attwood 2009; Smith 2007).

Discussion

NeoGAF’s response to gender stereotypes in video games centralizes sexual agency and sexual empowerment as key to achieving gender equality. Gaffers construct multiple, competing narratives of gender and sexism, effectively tying these issues into broader debates over the social significance of video games. Gaffers who employ a dominant reading do not problematize gendered imagery in games, and often provide market essentialist views of sex and sexuality by naturalizing the idea that game developers are right to cater to the strong sex drives of men (and, to a lesser degree, women). Those gaffers who do choose to problematize hyper-sexualized images of women in games (through either negotiated or oppositional readings) link objectification and stereotypes to real-world consequences, including cultural beliefs that reinforce patriarchal power dynamics. Still others opt to unsettle gender stereotypes in games by advocating for narratives that promote sexual agency among female protagonists. These competing readings are contextualized within broader feminist debates over the sexualization/pornification of culture, and the ability for women to embody sexual agency in a culture that reproduces stereotypes rooted in the objectified female body.

Similar to McKernan’s (2015) findings regarding racism in gaming promotional material, interactive audiences such as NeoGAF may serve to reify existing power dynamics. Just as some users in McKernan’s study employed colour-blind racism to explain and excuse the

racially problematic imagery in *Resident Evil 5*, several gaffers in this study reinforce hegemonic gendered ideologies by prioritizing the male gaze over female inclusivity. These gaffers are dismissive of feminist concerns over gender stereotypes and are quick to reject these concerns, often claiming it is “just a game”. Such users fail to connect the power of media to influence cultural understandings of gender and sexuality.

However, contrary to McKernan’s findings, a large body of gaffers in this study *challenged* existing gender dynamics by engaging with negotiated and oppositional readings over the importance of sexualization and empowerment in game content. These gaffers take a nuanced stance by recognizing the complexity of achieving sexual empowerment in a culture that places little value on de-objectifying women. Rather than dismissing feminist concerns, these gaffers elevate the voices of women in discussions of gender diversity. However, the limitations on accessing demographic content of gaffers means that it is unclear whether or not female voices were *actually* represented in these discussions. Despite this, this study contributes to scholarly discussions of gender representation and diversity in games by engaging with current feminist debates about the role of sexual agency and empowerment in a hypersexualized culture.

Future research is needed to assess the ideologies embedded in the various readings of online gaming communities, and the ways in which those ideologies are disrupted or negotiated over time. This type of research is especially timely given the changing demographics of gamers to include more women, and the increase in AAA games featuring female protagonists. Indeed, the decoding process is, according to S. Kim (2004), heavily influenced by an audience members’ social position, with “outsiders” (or those with minority positions) being more likely to engage in resistant readings of a text. To accomplish this, more research is needed on the independent gaming industry (those without the funding and clout of AAA studios) and efforts to diversify game content in these liminal spaces (notable independent games of interest might include *OneShot*, *Undertale*, *Never Alone*, *RiME*, and *Papo & Yo* to name a few).³ The choice to limit my focus on AAA games was due to limitations in the data— an overwhelming majority of the discussions revolved around AAA titles as opposed to independent games. A small (but not significant) portion of respondents noted that independent games are making waves by including diverse character casts, including queer and gender nonconforming characters. Indeed, by giving precedence to AAA games, the present study continues to centralize masculinity as the starting point for analysis. Further research should offer a comparative analysis of both AAA and independent game content and audiences, as well as audiences of increasingly popular mobile and casual games.

NeoGAF presents a unique case as an interactive audience given both its informal positionality, and its well-documented influence among game developers and journalists (Lenhart, Jones and MacGill 2008b). This influence likely contributes to the elevation of market-focused narratives that position diversity in terms of whether it can be sold to a presumed profitable audience. Further, the positionality of NeoGAF at the nexus of consumers and developers likely influences the frequent reduction of audiences and representation to singular identifiers (e.g., gender), with the assumption that audiences of a shared identifier will homogenously value that identifier and desire the same content in games. Future research is needed to investigate the way online spaces work to facilitate and mediate the negotiation of encoding and decoding between producers and audiences. Shaw’s (2017) attempt to merge Hall’s work with research on “affordances” (or the “action possibilities”

afforded consumers by various technologies and environments) provides a compelling starting point for future research into oppositional readings in gaming communities. For example, not all Internet gaming forums will produce the same discussions and narratives. NeoGAF's highly moderated structure and zero-tolerance policy for inflammatory speech undoubtedly influences the way users discuss issues of gender and sexism, and the requirement of institutional email addresses to gain membership means that members are likely to be older, working-class or educated. Given the unique positionality of NeoGAF, these results cannot be generalized to all gamers, or even to online gaming communities more broadly. Other, less moderated forums (such as GameFAQs, or Reddit) with open membership policies need further investigation to see how various readings of game content are produced and negotiated.

Notes

1. AAA games (pronounced "triple-A games") is an informal way of classifying video games that are produced and marketed with the highest industry budgets. They tend to come from prestigious game studios, and promise a high-quality gaming experience.
2. Intentionally provocative or jarring comments aimed at eliciting a negative response from others.
3. An emergent body of literature is tackling issues of representation in independent games, and the cultural and economic challenges faced by smaller gaming studios. See Brigid Kennedy (2020) for a discussion of queerness in *Gone Home*, and P. Crogan (2018) for a discussion of the growth of independent game development in the context of global neoliberal consumer culture.

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